How do plants compete for food?

Living things compete for food in a number of ways. Plants make their food by using sunlight, water and other ingredients to make sugars that help them grow. In areas that are crowded with plants, they must compete with other plants for sunlight and water.

Rainforest trees that have their leaves at the top of the canopy (the rainforest 'roof') get the most sunlight. The plants that are lower down get less sunlight, so they are not able to grow as easily, which is why they stay shorter.

☞ Look at the diagram and answer the questions that follow.



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How do plants compete for food? CONT'D

1 Which plants in this diagram have received the most sunlight? Colour two in light green, and then describe them below.

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2 Which plants are the most shaded from sunlight? Colour three in purple, and then describe them below.

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3 Which plants have photosynthesised less effectively than the tallest trees but more effectively than the lowest bushes? Colour two in dark green, and then describe them below.

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4 Which living things in this diagram act as decomposers? Colour two in brown, and then describe them below.

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5 Which plants provide links between trees but are not trees themselves? Colour two in orange, and then describe them below.

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6 Which plants attach themselves to larger plants in order to grow? Colour two in yellow, and then describe them below.

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7 Around the edges of the diagram, write the names of living things that might be found in the rainforest (for example, fungi, worms, caterpillar, frog, tree snake, possum, parrot and gibbon). Use arrows to point to the areas these living things would be found.

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